

Day 2: Stakeholder Mapping and Engagement Techniques

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Problem Statement

The focus of this phase was to identify all stakeholders affected by the project and analyze their roles, interests, and level of influence. Specifically, the task involved the following:

- Identify all stakeholders directly or indirectly affected by the inventory management system upgrade (including internal roles such as store managers, and external ones like customers and vendors).
- Create a stakeholder matrix that lists their roles, interests, and level of influence.
- Apply appropriate stakeholder analysis techniques to understand the impact of each stakeholder and determine suitable engagement strategies.

Approach Used

1. Identifying Stakeholders

The first step involved stakeholder identification. I began by reviewing the business case, which provided an initial understanding of the key stakeholders. To ensure completeness, I expanded on that list by identifying both internal and external individuals or groups who are directly or indirectly impacted by the project.

This included:

- **Internal:** Store Managers, Warehouse Supervisors, Purchasing and Procurement Managers, Inventory Manager, and the IT Team
- **External:** Vendors and Customers

This approach ensures a holistic view of all parties that should be considered during implementation and engagement planning.

2. Determining Stakeholder Interests

To understand stakeholder interests, I used a structured questioning technique. For each stakeholder, I asked:

- What is their role?
- What do they want from the project?
- How does the project affect them?
- What current problem are they facing that this project will address?

By responding to these questions for each stakeholder, I was able to clearly outline their unique interests and expectations. This provided a solid foundation for building tailored communication and engagement strategies.

Example:

- For the **Procurement Manager**, I identified that the project affects how stock insights are reported, and that they are interested in receiving timely, accurate data on high- and low-performing stock to support better purchasing decisions.
- For **Store Managers**, their interest was tied to improving day-to-day operations through better restocking alerts and fewer stockouts.

3. Stakeholder Analysis Techniques

I used the **Interest-Influence Matrix** to categorize and analyze each stakeholder. This technique helped determine:

- The level of **influence** a stakeholder has over the project's success
- The level of **interest** they have in the project's outcome

Stakeholders were then grouped as follows:

- High Interest / High Influence
- Medium Interest / Medium Influence
- Low Interest / Low Influence

This analysis was crucial in prioritizing communication efforts and determining who to involve actively, who to consult periodically, and who to simply monitor. It also ensured that the engagement plan aligned with each stakeholder's level of involvement and impact.

4. Developing the Engagement Plan

With the matrix and analysis complete, I developed an engagement strategy tailored to each stakeholder group. For each stakeholder, I documented:

- Their **engagement frequency** (e.g., weekly, bi-weekly, monthly)

- The **purpose** of engaging them (why their input is needed or what they need to be informed about)
- The **tools** to be used (e.g., dashboards, shared reports, internal platforms)
- Preferred **communication channels** (e.g., meetings, emails, direct calls)

This strategy was designed to encourage collaboration, provide timely updates, and minimize resistance during implementation.

Conclusion

This exercise enabled me to map out all relevant stakeholders, understand their needs and level of involvement, and plan for structured engagement throughout the project lifecycle. The stakeholder analysis formed the foundation for smoother communication and better alignment between the project team and all affected parties.